

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 757

By Baum

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Elizabeth Lorenza McPhee of Murfreesboro.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Elizabeth Lorenza McPhee of Murfreesboro; and

WHEREAS, an educator, volunteer, and fundraiser for charitable causes, Elizabeth Lorenza McPhee was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for her fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, the First Lady of Middle Tennessee State University (MTSU), Elizabeth McPhee worked alongside her husband since he was named president of the university in 2001, becoming an advocate, supporter, and mentor to generations of students, faculty, and staff; and

WHEREAS, born in Houston, Texas, on February 22, 1953, Elizabeth Lorenza McPhee was the daughter and youngest child of Antone and Alice Cooke; she attended J.J. Rose Elementary School and received her diploma from E.E. Worthing High School in Houston; and

WHEREAS, she earned a Bachelor of Arts degree in education with a minor in art from Prairie View A&M University in Texas, where she met her future husband, Dr. Sidney McPhee, and later completed graduate work at Oklahoma State University and the University of Louisville; and

WHEREAS, a professional educator for almost forty years, Elizabeth McPhee taught elementary school in four different states during her career, retiring in May 2014 after serving as a third-grade teacher at Reeves-Rogers Elementary School in Murfreesboro; and

WHEREAS, an active part of the MTSU community, Mrs. McPhee often served as a patron and planner for activities, fundraisers, and events at the university and with her sorority, Alpha Kappa Alpha; and

WHEREAS, an avid supporter of Blue Raider Athletics, she was the first recipient of the Blue Raider Impact Award in recognition of her work and advocacy for student athletes; on the day she died, she was working on a charitable event she was planning for MTSU's women's golf and soccer; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. McPhee organized and ran art camps for students at the MTSU President's Residence during summers and chaired the Alpha Kappa Alpha Teens program for teenage girls; she also led several groups of students, teachers, and parents on educational and cultural tours of China and hosted Chinese students and their families; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to awards and accolades, she was honored as an exceptional teacher in elementary education by the Bradley Academy Museum and Cultural Center, recognized by Delta Sigma Theta sorority's Rutherford County Alumnae Chapter for her international travels and outreach, and honored alongside her husband by the Murfreesboro City Schools Foundation in 2014 at its Excellence in Education Celebration and the 2022 NAACP President's Award by the Murfreesboro chapter of the NAACP; and

WHEREAS, in addition to her work with Alpha Kappa Alpha and Delta Kappa Gamma, Mrs. McPhee was actively involved with Belle Aire Baptist Church, Murfreesboro's Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Scholarship Board, Ascension Saint Thomas Rutherford Foundation Board, and the Murfreesboro City Schools Foundation Board, the Arts Center of Cannon County, and the Murfreesboro Domestic Violence Center; and

WHEREAS, Elizabeth McPhee was deeply devoted to her family, and she always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. McPhee is survived by her devoted husband of forty-five years, Dr. Sidney McPhee; their son, Dr. Sidney-Anthony McPhee; their daughter, Dr. Seneca Ann McPhee; adopted son, Trantell "Tweety" Knight; grandchildren, Asiah Ray Menke, Langston Anthony McPhee, Naomi Grace McPhee, and Nyla Jade McPhee; siblings, Amy Johnson-Wells and Melba Gipson; nieces and nephews, Albert Cooke, Jr., Anthony Cooke, Michael Cooke, Angela Gray, Alice Jones, and Arif Gipson; and

WHEREAS, in addition to her parents, Mrs. McPhee was preceded in death by her brother, Albert Cooke; and

WHEREAS, Elizabeth McPhee leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all her chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Elizabeth Lorenza McPhee, reflecting fondly upon her impeccable character and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mrs. McPhee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.